The art of conversation is about going beyond good communication, and getting to the level of mastery.

Mastering the art of conversation means that no only are you good at achieving your goals through talking, but also become a noticeably pleasant to talk to.

It is one of those uniquely human experiences that distills so much complexity and exhibits such infinite variety that it verges on the indefinable.

Presentation skills – To communicate effectively in the workplace, you need to be able to present your information clearly. Presentation skills doesn't just mean knowing how to put a good set of power point slides together, it means engaging and connecting with an audience to get your message across.

Why are presentation skills important?

Delivering effective presentations is critical in your professional and personal life. You'll need to hone your presentation skills in various areas, such as when giving a speech, convincing your partner to make a substantial purchase, and talking to friends and family about an important situation.

No matter if you're using them in a personal or professional setting, these are the skills that make it easier and more effective to convey your ideas, convince or persuade others, and experience success. A few of the benefits that often accompany improving your presentation skills include:

- Enriched written and verbal communication skills
- Enhanced confidence and self-image
- Boosted critical thinking and problem-solving capabilities
- Better motivational techniques
- Increased leadership skills
- Expanded time management, negotiation, and creativity

The better your presenting techniques, the more engaging your presentations will be. You could also have greater opportunities to make positive impacts in business and other areas of your life.

Effective presentation skills

Imagine yourself in the audience at a TED Talk or sitting with your coworkers at a big meeting held by your employer. What would you be looking for in how they deliver their message? What would make you feel engaged?

These are a few questions to ask yourself as you review this list of some of the most effective presentation skills.

Verbal communication

How you use language and deliver messages play essential roles in how your audience will receive your presentation. Speak clearly and confidently, projecting your voice enough to ensure everyone can hear. Think before you speak, pausing when necessary and tailoring the way you talk to resonate with your particular audience.

Body language

Body language combines various critical elements, including posture, gestures, eye contact, expressions, and position in front of the audience. Body language is one of the elements that can instantly transform a presentation that would otherwise be dull into one that's dynamic and interesting.

Voice projection

The ability to project your voice improves your presentation by allowing your audience to hear what you're saying. It also increases your confidence to help settle any lingering nerves while also making your message more engaging. To project your voice, stand comfortably with your shoulders back. Take deep breaths to power your speaking voice and ensure you enunciate every syllable you speak.

Posture

How you present yourself plays a role in your body language and ability to project your voice. It also sets the tone for the presentation. Avoid slouching or looking overly tense. Instead, remain open, upright, and adaptable while taking the formality of the occasion into account.

Story telling

Incorporating storytelling into a presentation is an effective strategy used by many powerful public speakers. It has the power to bring your subject to life and pique the audience's curiosity. Don't be afraid to tell a personal story, slowly building up suspense or adding a dramatic moment. And, of course, be sure to end with a positive takeaway to drive your point home.

Active listening

Active listening is a valuable skill all on its own. When you understand and thoughtfully respond to what you hear—whether it's in a conversation or during a presentation—you'll likely deepen your personal relationships and actively engage audiences during a presentation. As part of your presentation skill set, it helps catch and maintain the audience's attention, helping them remain focused while minimizing passive response, ensuring the message is delivered correctly, and encouraging a call to action.

Stage presence

During a presentation, projecting confidence can help keep your audience engaged. Stage presence can help you connect with your audience and encourage them to want to watch you. To improve your presence, try amping up your normal demeanor by infusing it with a bit of enthusiasm. Project confidence and keep your information interesting.

Watch your audience as you're presenting. If you're holding their attention, it likely means you're connecting well with them.

Self-awareness

Monitoring your own emotions and reactions will allow you to react well in various situations. It helps you remain personable throughout your presentation and handle feedback well. Self-awareness can help soothe nervousness during presentations, allowing you to perform more effectively.

Writing skills

Writing is a form of presentation. Sharp writing skills can help you master your presentation's outline to ensure you stay on message and remain clear about your

objectives from the beginning until the end. It’s also helpful to have strong writing abilities for creating compelling slides and other visual aids.

Understanding an audience

When you understand your audience's needs and interests, you can design your presentation around them. In turn, you'll deliver maximum value to them and enhance your ability to make your message easy to understand.

What are public speaking skills?

Public speaking skills are soft skills that showcase how well you can speak and engage your listeners. Influential public speakers have the power to persuade, inform and educate others. It helps you sway opinions, motivate others and become a natural leader. Mastery of this skill can help you advance your career, increase confidence, improve leadership skills, develop vocabulary and ensure personal development.

Top 6 public speaking skills

Here are the top six public speaking skills to master:

Communication

Being able to communicate an idea or thought clearly is an essential skill for public speaking. In order to become an effective communicator, you need to master various elements of communication.

You require excellent diction to ensure that the audience understands every word you say. Another critical element of communication is the ability to control your voice and speed of talking. If you talk too softly or loudly, the audience may fail to understand your point. Similarly, if you speak too slow or too fast, the audience may lose interest in what you have to say.

Excellent public speakers are experts at adjusting their speech patterns based on the audience's level of expertise. For example, when speaking at a technology conference, you should convey the technical concepts in such a way that even the most non-technical person can understand them.

Clear articulation

Good public speakers pronounce words clearly and use proper grammar while avoiding verbal crutches like “um” and “ah”. Verbal crutches can distract the audience from what

the speaker is actually trying to say. Public speakers with clear articulation lend more clarity to their thoughts because they have excellent command over the language, use appropriate words and have a rich vocabulary. Apart from reducing verbosity, clear articulation gives you the confidence to speak at small and large meetings.

Presentation style

Even the most tedious and technical topic becomes interesting when you present it the right way. This requires superior presentation skills. However, good presentation skill is not limited to creating eye-catching and interesting slides. It also includes facial expression, vocal tone and body language. Using the right presentation style, you can make boring topics engaging and interesting. To make your presentation memorable and capture the audience's attention, start your presentation by introducing yourself or sharing a few industry statistics. Use a joke or story to inject some humour in your speech. Your presentation style should have the power to engage the audience.

Confidence

Another essential skill of a public speaker is confidence. Often, even good communicators who feel comfortable addressing a small audience may lose confidence when talking to a large audience. Problems like nervousness and stage fright may disappear when you are confident about your skills. Employers often prefer confident speakers because they are more likely to share information in a meaningful and authoritative manner. Your level of confidence impacts how you portray and carry yourself when talking to an audience.

Passion

Communication becomes easier when you are passionate about the topic of your speech. Without passion, your communication can fail to educate and inform others. Exuding a level of expertise in your speech delivery is essential to create a connection with your audience. When delivering a speech on a topic that does not excite you, dig deep into the topic and try to find things that might interest you. This helps you address the gathering with authenticity and makes you look like an expert.

Ability to connect with the audience

When delivering a seminar or addressing an issue during a meeting, you must connect with your audience. For creating a connection, assess your audience's needs. For instance, some people are comfortable with technical terms while others are not. Some prefer a light-hearted conversation, including jokes and humour, while others may prefer a professional conversation. Excellent public speakers create an atmosphere that engages and excites the listeners.

How to improve your public speaking skills

Here are the top six ways to improve your public speaking skills and use them to advance your career:

1. Practise speaking

The more you speak with others, the more comfortable you become in addressing large gatherings. You can practise your speaking skills by enrolling in a public speaking class. Also, plan what you have to say in advance and read it aloud again and again. Start by reading the speech to yourself. Then read it in front of your family members or colleagues and ask for their honest feedback. Make a video recording of your rehearsal so that you can evaluate your speaking skills and spot any areas of improvement.

2. Focus on your body language

Body language is a nonverbal communication skill that supports your public speaking skills. When moving on the stage, always keep your shoulder and spine straight and have a gentle smile on your face. Avoid standing behind desks, tables or chairs when talking to the audience. Use gestures to emphasise a point and move to different areas of the stage according to the flow of your presentation. Your facial expression must match the overall energy and tone of your speech.

3. Work on the tone of your voice

During presentations, your audience can lose interest if you use a monotone voice. You should practise various voice modulations and try different pitches to draw the audience. Listen to famous public speakers and understand how they use the tone of their voice to make their presentations engaging.

4. Practise diaphragmatic breathing

Often, first-time public speakers may suffer from speech anxiety, which results in nervousness and stage fear. To avoid speech anxiety, practise diaphragmatic breathing as it helps reduce anxiety and allows better control over your voice, volume and pitch.

5. Make eye contact with your audience

Being able to engage your audience while delivering a speech is an essential quality of a public speaker. To improve this, ensure you make eye contact with them. Practise eye contact in your home or office when you talk to your friends or colleagues.

6. Be self-assured

Audiences easily connect with speakers who look confident. When you are self-assured and confident of your skills, you successfully create an emotional connection that helps in delivering the right idea or message.